Confusion Concerning the Coming

Shaken by a false spirit, a fabricated prophecy and a forged letter, the Thessalonians feared the Day of the Lord had come. Paul's correction: the apostasy and the man of sin must come first — and the antidote is to remember.

Where this study fits

2 Thessalonians · seven studies · this study highlighted

01 1:1–2
Introduction and Background

02 1:3–12
Paul's Admiration for the Thessalonians

03 2:1–5
Confusion Concerning the Coming

04 2:6–12
The Removal of the Restrainer

05 2:13–17
The Day of the Lord and Believers

06 3:1–12
Serving While Waiting

07 3:13–18
My Brother's Keeper

Grace and peace frame the letter (1:2; 3:16–18): persecution in chapter 1, prophecy in chapter 2, correction in chapter 3.

Two days distinguished

Introduction · The Rapture and the Day of the Lord

The Rapture — “the Day of Christ”
παρουσία · ἐπισυναγωγή coming · gathering together

- The church taken out — in a moment
- The dead raised, the living caught up
- 1 Thess 4:16–18

vs

The Day of the Lord

- Judgment — seven years
- Blessing — one thousand years
- For the Christ-rejecting world
- 1 Thess 5:1–3

The Rapture comes before the Day of the Lord — but it does not start it. The Day of the Lord starts later, when the man of sin is revealed.

Three channels of deception

2 Thessalonians 2:1–2 · I — The confusion by apostates

By spirit

- A false message in tongues
- Test the spirits (1 John 4:1)

By word

- A fabricated prophecy
- Errors can occur in any gift

By letter
ἐπιστολή letter · G1992

- Forged — “as if from us”
- Paul signs every letter (3:17)

The claim · ἐνίστημι: not that the Day was near, but that it was already here — “you missed the Rapture.”

Behind all three: Satan, the great deceiver. Don’t be shaken in mind (σαλεύω) or troubled in emotion (θροέω).

What must come first

2 Thessalonians 2:3–4 · II.A — The error of the deception

A

The Rapture

The true church taken out — pictured by Philadelphia

Rev 3:7–13

B

The apostasy

A pervasive, global departure from the faith

ἀποστασία · Laodicea

C

The man of sin revealed

He makes a seven-year covenant with Israel

Dan 9:27

D

The Day of the Lord

Seven years of Tribulation, then the Millennium

2:3

Walvoord: “Paul was declaring that the Day of the Lord cannot come until first a pervasive, global departure from the faith.” Study Note: some pretribulationists read apostasia as the Rapture itself — either way, the church is not in that Day.

The man of sin: his aliases

Conclusion · Other names for the “son of perdition,” the final world dictator

Dan 7–9	The little horn · a king of fierce countenance · the prince who is to come	— Dan 7:8; 8:23; 9:26
Dan 9–11	The one who makes desolate · the willful king	— Dan 9:27; 11:36–45
Zech 11	A foolish shepherd	— Zech 11:15–17
2 Thess 2	The man of sin · the son of perdition · the lawless (wicked) one	**ἁμαρτία · ἀπώλεια** 2:3, 8
Rev 6, 13	The rider on the white horse · the beast out of the sea	— Rev 6:2; 13:1–2

His agenda — revealed now, doing these things later

2 Thessalonians 2:4 · II.A.2.b–d — His description

A **Opposes God**

Against the true God, Jehovah

B **Above God**

Claims the worship that belongs to Jehovah only

C **Above all gods**

No other religion allowed — worship him or die

D **Sits in the temple**

ναός — at the midpoint of the Tribulation (Dan 9:27)

E **Shows himself God**

“I am God” — over the whole world

✓ **A picture: 167 B.C.**

Antiochus Epiphanes set Zeus — with his own face — in the temple

“Do you not remember?”

2 Thessalonians 2:5 · II.B — The antidote for the deception

A

Hear it

Pay attention to what you hear

first

B

Review it

Think about it during the week

often

C

Teach it

Explain it to family and friends

“you’ll know it when you teach it”

The antidote to every deception: remember, review, and teach what God has already said. You are not going into that Tribulation.

Discuss and apply

2 Thessalonians 2:1–5 · from the study's posted questions and applications

Discuss

1. What three channels did the deception come through, and how should believers guard against each?

2. What two things must happen before the Day of the Lord can begin, and how will the man of sin be revealed?

Apply

Test What You Hear
Take one prophecy claim you've heard and look up the passages yourself before accepting it.

Teach It to Keep It
Explain the difference between the Rapture and the Day of the Lord to a family member or friend this week.

In one line: Don't be shaken: the apostasy and the man of sin must come first — so remember, review and teach what God has said.